

3. Here is a tip that may not apply right now, but could affect a future upgrade: remember that hard disks are mechanical devices, and most often require an upgrade or repair when the mechanical system fails. Remember that the mechanical system can fail due to overheating.

Do your hard disk a favour, and get a hard disk fan. This can be mounted either directly above the hard disk or right in front of it. If it is mounted above the hard disk, it will take up the space of one IDE drive, but it will be worth it.

You can do another simple thing to increase the life of your hard disk: go to the power saver settings in Windows and set the hard disks to turn off after 3, 5, or 10 minutes of idling. This has the negative effect of your sometimes needing to wait a while for the hard disk to turn back on, but your disk will be happy you did it—it will not spin nearly as much.

4. Some people tend to rush in to upgrade if the Net runs slow. Don't do that! It could just be a modem problem. Take your modem to a technician and see if it can be repaired. There are several factors involved, including your phone line—ask your technician to do some troubleshooting. You might need to get a new modem, but that is better than going for a more expensive upgrade.

Of course, you could do away with the modem altogether and go in for broadband. Some broadband services don't require a modem on your end at all—just a network card. Some require that you purchase an ADSL modem.

5. We've said it before, and we'll say it again: get RAM, get RAM, get RAM! If Windows runs slow, you may be tempted to think of a system upgrade. You might think your computer just isn't powerful enough to run Windows XP.

In such cases, recall that Windows XP requires a lot of RAM to function properly. Buy more RAM. The more RAM you give XP, the happier it will be—to a point. In some cases, 512 MB will do just